

BPD RECOVERY WORKBOOK

Skills for Emotional Stability
& Healthier Relationships

DBT-Informed Exercises Including:

Wise Mind | STOP Skill | Radical Acceptance

DEAR MAN | Opposite Action | Diary Cards

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BPD RECOVERY WORKBOOK

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This workbook is for educational purposes only.

It is not a substitute for professional DBT therapy or mental health treatment.

If you are in crisis, call 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).

UNDERSTANDING BPD

Borderline Personality Disorder is characterized by:

- Intense and unstable emotions that change rapidly
- Fear of abandonment (real or imagined)
- Unstable relationships (idealization/devaluation)
- Unstable sense of self/identity
- Impulsive behaviors (spending, substances, risky behavior)
- Chronic feelings of emptiness
- Intense anger that is hard to control
- Dissociation under stress
- Self-harm or suicidal thoughts

IMPORTANT: BPD is NOT a life sentence. With skills training (like DBT), many people achieve significant recovery.

WISE MIND MEDITATION

Find a comfortable position and close your eyes

Breathe in... imagine breathing in wisdom

Breathe out... release judgment

Ask yourself: What does my Wise Mind know right now?

Wait for the answer to come - don't force it

Wise Mind speaks quietly. It doesn't argue or justify.

Reflections:

WISE MIND PRACTICE: Stone on the Lake

Imagine you are a lake... vast, deep, calm

Emotions are stones thrown into your surface

They create ripples (Emotion Mind) but do not change the depths

Your depths remain still and knowing (Wise Mind)

Let the stone sink... observe it... let the surface settle

Reflections:

WISE MIND WORKSHEET

What does EMOTION MIND say? _____

What does REASONABLE MIND say? _____

What does WISE MIND say? _____

How do I know this is Wise Mind? _____

What action aligns with Wise Mind? _____

Reflections:

STOP SKILL PRACTICE (1/5)

S - STOP: Don't react. Freeze.

T - TAKE A STEP BACK: Breathe. Don't act on impulse.

O - OBSERVE: What is happening? What am I feeling?

P - PROCEED MINDFULLY: Act with Wise Mind.

Situation 1:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

Situation 2:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

STOP SKILL PRACTICE (2/5)

S - STOP: Don't react. Freeze.

T - TAKE A STEP BACK: Breathe. Don't act on impulse.

O - OBSERVE: What is happening? What am I feeling?

P - PROCEED MINDFULLY: Act with Wise Mind.

Situation 3:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

Situation 4:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

STOP SKILL PRACTICE (3/5)

S - STOP: Don't react. Freeze.

T - TAKE A STEP BACK: Breathe. Don't act on impulse.

O - OBSERVE: What is happening? What am I feeling?

P - PROCEED MINDFULLY: Act with Wise Mind.

Situation 5:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

Situation 6:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

STOP SKILL PRACTICE (4/5)

S - STOP: Don't react. Freeze.

T - TAKE A STEP BACK: Breathe. Don't act on impulse.

O - OBSERVE: What is happening? What am I feeling?

P - PROCEED MINDFULLY: Act with Wise Mind.

Situation 7:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

Situation 8:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

STOP SKILL PRACTICE (5/5)

S - STOP: Don't react. Freeze.

T - TAKE A STEP BACK: Breathe. Don't act on impulse.

O - OBSERVE: What is happening? What am I feeling?

P - PROCEED MINDFULLY: Act with Wise Mind.

Situation 9:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

Situation 10:

What happened: _____

My urge/impulse: _____

S - I stopped by: _____

T - I stepped back by: _____

O - I observed: _____

P - I proceeded by: _____

Outcome: _____

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE WORKSHEET (1/4)

Radical Acceptance means:

- Accepting reality AS IT IS (not approving of it)
- Letting go of fighting against what already happened
- Choosing to stop adding suffering to pain

Pain + Non-Acceptance = SUFFERING

Pain + Acceptance = PAIN (just pain, which passes)

What I need to accept: _____

Ways I am fighting reality: _____

The cost of non-acceptance (how is fighting making things worse?):

Turning the mind statement (I choose to accept...): _____

Half-smile practice: Can I relax my face and half-smile? _____

Willing hands: Can I unclench and open my palms? _____

How I feel after practicing acceptance: _____

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE WORKSHEET (2/4)

What I need to accept: _____

Ways I am fighting reality: _____

The cost of non-acceptance (how is fighting making things worse?):

Turning the mind statement (I choose to accept...): _____

Half-smile practice: Can I relax my face and half-smile? _____

Willing hands: Can I unclench and open my palms? _____

How I feel after practicing acceptance: _____

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE WORKSHEET (3/4)

What I need to accept: _____

Ways I am fighting reality: _____

The cost of non-acceptance (how is fighting making things worse?):

Turning the mind statement (I choose to accept...): _____

Half-smile practice: Can I relax my face and half-smile? _____

Willing hands: Can I unclench and open my palms? _____

How I feel after practicing acceptance: _____

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE WORKSHEET (4/4)

What I need to accept: _____

Ways I am fighting reality: _____

The cost of non-acceptance (how is fighting making things worse?):

Turning the mind statement (I choose to accept...): _____

Half-smile practice: Can I relax my face and half-smile? _____

Willing hands: Can I unclench and open my palms? _____

How I feel after practicing acceptance: _____

DEAR MAN: Asking for a raise/promotion at work

D - DESCRIBE:

State the facts of the situation (no judgments):

E - EXPRESS:

Share how you feel about it (use 'I' statements):

A - ASSERT:

Ask clearly for what you want/need:

R - REINFORCE:

Explain the positive effects if they cooperate:

M - MINDFUL:

Stay focused, don't get sidetracked. Broken record:

A - APPEAR CONFIDENT:

Eye contact, steady voice, stand tall:

N - NEGOTIATE:

Be willing to give to get. My compromise:

DEAR MAN: Setting a boundary with a family member

D - DESCRIBE:

State the facts of the situation (no judgments):

E - EXPRESS:

Share how you feel about it (use 'I' statements):

A - ASSERT:

Ask clearly for what you want/need:

R - REINFORCE:

Explain the positive effects if they cooperate:

M - MINDFUL:

Stay focused, don't get sidetracked. Broken record:

A - APPEAR CONFIDENT:

Eye contact, steady voice, stand tall:

N - NEGOTIATE:

Be willing to give to get. My compromise:

DEAR MAN: Expressing needs to a romantic partner

D - DESCRIBE:

State the facts of the situation (no judgments):

E - EXPRESS:

Share how you feel about it (use 'I' statements):

A - ASSERT:

Ask clearly for what you want/need:

R - REINFORCE:

Explain the positive effects if they cooperate:

M - MINDFUL:

Stay focused, don't get sidetracked. Broken record:

A - APPEAR CONFIDENT:

Eye contact, steady voice, stand tall:

N - NEGOTIATE:

Be willing to give to get. My compromise:

DEAR MAN: Saying no to an unreasonable request

D - DESCRIBE:

State the facts of the situation (no judgments):

E - EXPRESS:

Share how you feel about it (use 'I' statements):

A - ASSERT:

Ask clearly for what you want/need:

R - REINFORCE:

Explain the positive effects if they cooperate:

M - MINDFUL:

Stay focused, don't get sidetracked. Broken record:

A - APPEAR CONFIDENT:

Eye contact, steady voice, stand tall:

N - NEGOTIATE:

Be willing to give to get. My compromise:

DEAR MAN: Addressing a conflict with a friend

D - DESCRIBE:

State the facts of the situation (no judgments):

E - EXPRESS:

Share how you feel about it (use 'I' statements):

A - ASSERT:

Ask clearly for what you want/need:

R - REINFORCE:

Explain the positive effects if they cooperate:

M - MINDFUL:

Stay focused, don't get sidetracked. Broken record:

A - APPEAR CONFIDENT:

Eye contact, steady voice, stand tall:

N - NEGOTIATE:

Be willing to give to get. My compromise:

OPPOSITE ACTION: ANGER

Urge: Attack, yell, slam things

Opposite: Gently avoid, be kind, take space

Situation: _____

Emotion intensity before (0-10): ____

Is my emotion JUSTIFIED by the facts? (Check the facts first)

Even if justified, is ACTING on the urge EFFECTIVE? _____

My opposite action plan: _____

Did I act ALL THE WAY opposite? (half measures don't work): _____

Emotion intensity after (0-10): ____

What I noticed: _____

OPPOSITE ACTION: SHAME

Urge: Hide, isolate, keep secrets

Opposite: Share with safe person, hold head up

Situation: _____

Emotion intensity before (0-10): ____

Is my emotion JUSTIFIED by the facts? (Check the facts first)

Even if justified, is ACTING on the urge EFFECTIVE? _____

My opposite action plan: _____

Did I act ALL THE WAY opposite? (half measures don't work): _____

Emotion intensity after (0-10): ____

What I noticed: _____

OPPOSITE ACTION: FEAR

Urge: Avoid, escape, freeze

Opposite: Approach what you fear (if safe)

Situation: _____

Emotion intensity before (0-10): ____

Is my emotion JUSTIFIED by the facts? (Check the facts first)

Even if justified, is ACTING on the urge EFFECTIVE? _____

My opposite action plan: _____

Did I act ALL THE WAY opposite? (half measures don't work): _____

Emotion intensity after (0-10): ____

What I noticed: _____

OPPOSITE ACTION: SADNESS

Urge: Withdraw, stay in bed, isolate

Opposite: Get active, reach out, engage

Situation: _____

Emotion intensity before (0-10): ____

Is my emotion JUSTIFIED by the facts? (Check the facts first)

Even if justified, is ACTING on the urge EFFECTIVE? _____

My opposite action plan: _____

Did I act ALL THE WAY opposite? (half measures don't work): _____

Emotion intensity after (0-10): ____

What I noticed: _____

BUILDING A LIFE WORTH LIVING

VALUES - What matters most to me:

Relationships: _____

Work/Purpose: _____

Health: _____

Fun/Leisure: _____

Spirituality: _____

GOALS aligned with my values:

Short-term (this week): _____

Medium-term (this month): _____

Long-term (this year): _____

POSITIVE EXPERIENCES to build into my life:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

MY CRISIS PLAN

Warning signs I'm heading toward crisis:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Distress tolerance skills to try FIRST:

- TIPP (Temperature, Intense exercise, Paced breathing, Paired relaxation)
- Self-soothe with 5 senses
- IMPROVE the moment
- Pros and cons of acting on urge

People I can call:

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Professional support:

Therapist: _____ Phone: _____

Crisis line: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

DAILY DIARY CARD - Week 1

Category	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Emotions (0-5)							
Urges to self-harm							
Urges to use substances							
Mindfulness practice							
Interpersonal skill							
Emotion regulation							
Distress tolerance							
Skills used (list)							
Medications taken							

Notes: _____

DAILY DIARY CARD - Week 2

Category	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Emotions (0-5)							
Urges to self-harm							
Urges to use substances							
Mindfulness practice							
Interpersonal skill							
Emotion regulation							
Distress tolerance							
Skills used (list)							
Medications taken							

Notes: _____

DAILY DIARY CARD - Week 3

Category	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Emotions (0-5)							
Urges to self-harm							
Urges to use substances							
Mindfulness practice							
Interpersonal skill							
Emotion regulation							
Distress tolerance							
Skills used (list)							
Medications taken							

Notes: _____

DAILY DIARY CARD - Week 4

Category	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Emotions (0-5)							
Urges to self-harm							
Urges to use substances							
Mindfulness practice							
Interpersonal skill							
Emotion regulation							
Distress tolerance							
Skills used (list)							
Medications taken							

Notes: _____

DAILY DIARY CARD - Week 5

Category	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Emotions (0-5)							
Urges to self-harm							
Urges to use substances							
Mindfulness practice							
Interpersonal skill							
Emotion regulation							
Distress tolerance							
Skills used (list)							
Medications taken							

Notes: _____

MY BPD RECOVERY MILESTONES

Celebrate every step forward, no matter how small:

- | | |
|--|-------------|
| ☐ Used a skill instead of acting on an urge | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Went a full day without self-harm | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Expressed a need without exploding | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Accepted something I couldn't change | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Stayed in Wise Mind during conflict | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Asked for help appropriately | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Completed a full week of diary cards | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Repaired a relationship after conflict | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Recognized an emotion before it escalated | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Chose opposite action successfully | Date: _____ |

You are NOT your diagnosis. You are a whole person learning new skills.

Recovery is possible. You deserve a life worth living.